

Australia Daily Brief

Thursday, October 1, 2026

1,567 words · 6 min read

RE: NZ Parliament dissolved for Nov 7 vote · PNG-Australia Wantok Warrior drill opens · American Samoa sues US over 31-million-acre seabed lease · Fiji locks in campaign rules · ASX falls to four-month low

ASX 200

8,614

-1.01%

AUD/USD

0.6936

-1.03%

NZX 50

13,811

-0.10%

NZD/USD

0.5603

-0.95%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 New Zealand's Parliament was dissolved on Thursday, confirming the formal campaign for the November 7 general election, with advance voting opening October 26.
- 2 Papua New Guinea and Australia opened Exercise Wantok Warrior 2026 near Port Moresby, with more than 230 personnel from both defence forces training on interoperability.
- 3 An American Samoa environmental group sued the US government over a proposed 31-million-acre deep-sea mining lease sale set for November 19, arguing it would be the first opening of US waters to seabed mining.

• TOP STORIES

NZ-POLITICS

New Zealand Parliament dissolved for November 7 election

New Zealand's Parliament was dissolved on Thursday, opening the formal campaign for the November 7 general election, Reuters reports. Advance voting begins October 26. The contest facing **Christopher Luxon's** National-led coalition, formed with ACT and NZ First in 2023, is described as tight, with dissolution falling 37 days before polling day.

per Reuters: "New Zealand Parliament dissolved ahead of tight November vote"

AU-DEFENSE

PNG and Australia open Exercise Wantok Warrior 2026

More than 230 Papua New Guinean and Australian military personnel have begun combined operational training near Port Moresby under Exercise Wantok Warrior 2026, the Post Courier reports. The exercise strengthens cooperation and interoperability between the two defence forces, following last week's pledge by Pacific defence ministers on collective regional security.

per PNG Post-Courier: "PNG, Australia maintains defence cooperation through Wantok Warrior 2026"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

American Samoa group sues Washington over seabed mining lease sale

Fa'asao Amerika Samoa and the Conservation Council for Hawaii filed suit in August challenging a US plan to lease *more than 31 million acres* of seabed around American Samoa, with the sale scheduled for November 19 and initial leases running 20 years. The complaint says the United States has never before opened its waters to deep-sea mining. Spokesperson **Seumalu Elora Raymond** said regulators had not adequately assessed risks to whales, turtles and sharks.

per RNZ Pacific: "American Samoa environmental group sues US govt over deep sea mining plans"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji locks in strict campaign rules ahead of 2027 poll deadline

Fiji's Electoral Commission has adopted the Campaign Limitation Rules 2026, barring the use of taxpayer-funded and state resources for campaigning and restricting where campaign materials may be displayed, effective October 20. Eleven parties, the most since Fiji's 2014 return to democratic rule, are confirmed to contest the election, which must be held by February 6, 2027. *More than 723,000* voters were registered as of June 30.

per RNZ Pacific: "Fiji election: Strict campaign rules set for parties and candidates"

● OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

[Canberra weighs tearing up \\$2.3B detention contract](#) · Politico Canberra Playbook

Politico's Canberra Playbook reports the government is weighing whether to tear up a *\$2.3 billion* immigration detention contract, describing the arrangement as 'on thin ice.' No replacement provider or decision date has been disclosed.

AU-DEFENSE

[WA police given powers to bar protesters from defence expo](#) · ABC News

Western Australian police have been granted additional powers to exclude named individuals from protesting at a land forces defence industry exposition. Earlier editions of the event in other states drew sustained demonstrations against arms exhibitors.

AU-DEFENSE

[Keogh says veterans ties intact after health cap backdown](#) · ABC News

Veterans' Affairs Minister **Matt Keogh** said he can still work with the veteran community after reversing a proposed cap on health provision. The reversal lands days before a Four Corners investigation into for-profit providers billing the Department of Veterans' Affairs.

AU-POLITICS

[Coalition vows to repeal union procurement laws](#) · The Australian

Deputy Liberal leader **Jane Hume** pledged a Coalition government would repeal procurement laws the opposition says favour union-linked contractors and reinstate a national construction industry watchdog. The policy would reshape eligibility rules for federal infrastructure and defence estate contracts.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Foreign and local bidders circle \\$900m leasing firm FleetPartners](#) · The Australian

Private equity bidders, including Japanese firms, are preparing final offers for FleetPartners, a \$900 million novated leasing company, with local private equity also in the race, The Australian reports. The contest underscores continued foreign interest in Australian financial services assets.

• STAT OF THE DAY

31 million acres

Seabed proposed for a US deep-sea mining lease sale near American Samoa

Fa'asao Amerika Samoa and the Conservation Council for Hawaii are suing to block the November 19 sale, arguing Washington has never before opened its waters to seabed mining.

RNZ Pacific

• PACIFIC WIRE

KIRIBATI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

[Kiribati cabinet backs plan to 're-engineer' climate finance](#)

Kiribati's cabinet has approved work on a proposal to fundamentally rethink how climate finance reaches small island developing states ahead of COP31, Islands Business reports.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

[Solomon Islands pledges free universal education by 2027](#)

Solomon Islands delegation lead **Martin Kwaifono** told the UN Human Rights Council the government is pursuing free universal education by 2027, after accepting *140 of 181* recommendations from its Universal Periodic Review. The country acceded to the UN Convention against Transnational Organised Crime on August 27.

PALAU · ABC PACIFIC

[Palau marks 32nd Independence Day after taking Forum chair](#)

Palau celebrated its 32nd Independence Day this week, ABC Pacific reports, days after President **Surangel Whipps Jr** took over as Pacific Islands Forum chair at the Koror leaders meeting in early September.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

[Investment disputes test Pacific sovereignty over seabed resources](#)

Pacific island states manage roughly *30 percent* of the world's oceans and seas, Islands Business reports, and face growing exposure to costly investor-state arbitration as mining and resource disputes multiply across the Blue Pacific.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

Missing Fiji court cocaine evidence now totals 52kg

A further batch of missing evidence has brought the total cocaine unaccounted for from Fiji's High Court to 52 kilograms, ABC Pacific reports, up from roughly 40 kilograms reported missing in late September.

SAMOA · ABC PACIFIC

Samoa Observer accuses PM's son of deleting reporter's photos

The Samoa Observer has accused the prime minister's son of deleting a reporter's photographs, ABC Pacific reports, raising fresh press freedom concerns in Samoa.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand house prices fall to lowest since early 2021

New Zealand house prices fell to their lowest level since early 2021, Bloomberg reports, adding an economic headache for **Christopher Luxon's** government heading into the November 7 election.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Guides association presses for cap on Australian fishing guides

The New Zealand Professional Guides Association wants a cap on seasonal Australian fishing guides, who association president **Dean Bell** says operate through a tax arrangement that does not require them to pay GST or tax in New Zealand. Minister for Hunting and Fishing **James Meager** has pointed to the closer economic relations agreement with Australia.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Minns presses Canberra for spending restraint after inflation spike

New South Wales Premier **Chris Minns** called on the federal government to rein in spending after the latest inflation figures, adding internal Labor pressure on **Anthony Albanese** and **Jim Chalmers**. The intervention came as Chalmers played down an apparent rift with Reserve Bank governor **Michele Bullock**.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Labor MP accuses new Greens leader of 'prejudice' over Gaza remarks

Labor MP **Josh Burns** accused new Greens leader **David Shoebridge** of 'prejudice' after Shoebridge said his party has strong connections with Jewish Australians 'fighting a genocide.' Shoebridge was elected leader on September 30 after **Larissa Waters** stepped down.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Australia's card surcharge ban takes effect; NZ weighs following

Australia's ban on credit and debit card surcharges took effect Thursday, and New Zealand's National-led government says its intention to pursue a similar ban is unchanged, RNZ reports. New Zealand's Commerce Commission cuts to interchange fee caps are expected to save businesses up to \$290 million a year.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Lynas Rare Earths to buy Meteoric Resources for \$672 million

Australia's Lynas Rare Earths agreed to acquire Meteoric Resources for \$672 *million*, Reuters reports, consolidating its position in rare earths supply chains central to critical minerals diplomacy with the United States and Japan.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

ASX 200 closes at four-month low

The ASX 200 closed at a four-month low of 8,614 *points*, down 1.01 percent, with all eleven sectors finishing in negative territory, ABC reports.

TRADE-ECONOMY · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Economists warn of global shock risk as inflation stays high

A growing risk exists that Australia would be hit hard by a global financial shock while inflation remains elevated, SMH reports, as rate rises squeeze first-home buyers and push some borrowers toward negative equity.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · PIF COMMUNIQUES

Pacific ministers reaffirm unity ahead of Palau Forum meeting

Pacific foreign ministers reaffirmed regional unity ahead of the Palau Leaders Meeting, FBC News reports, as the Forum chair transitions from Solomon Islands to Palau.

• UPCOMING

OCT
20

Fiji's Campaign Limitation Rules 2026 take effect

Bars state resources from campaign activity as eleven parties, the most since 2014, prepare to contest an election due by February 6, 2027.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for New Zealand's general election

First opportunity to cast ballots ahead of the November 7 poll, following Thursday's dissolution of Parliament.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether Christopher Luxon's National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues, with implications for NZ defence and foreign policy settings.

NOV
19

US deep-sea mining lease sale scheduled for American Samoa waters

Fa'asao Amerika Samoa and the Conservation Council for Hawaii are suing to block a sale covering more than 31 million acres, the first opening of US waters to seabed mining.

FEB
6

Constitutional deadline for Fiji's next general election

Sets the outer bound for a vote that already has eleven confirmed parties contesting under new campaign rules.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

POLITICO CANBERRA PLAYBOOK

Australia's climate chief vows harder line on misinformation

Australia's climate chief promised a tougher stance on climate misinformation, Politico's Canberra Playbook reports, ahead of the country's COP31 diplomatic push.

AU-DEFENSE

ABC NEWS

Four Corners probes for-profit firms billing veterans affairs

An upcoming Four Corners investigation finds private, for-profit companies billing the Department of Veterans' Affairs for services ranging from medicinal cannabis dispensing to compensation claim cuts, ABC reports. The program airs October 5.

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

ASPI STRATEGIST

Fault Lines – Taiwan's arms hopes, Indonesia's carrier, Fiji's chiefs

The roundup surveys regional security and defence developments across Northeast Asia, Southeast Asia and Oceania over the two-week period, part of ASPI's Defence Strategy Program monitoring of the regional order.

Argument: ASPI's fortnightly regional security monitor tracks developments from September 18 to October 1, including Taiwan's arms procurement ambitions, Indonesia's carrier plans, and dynamics among Fiji's traditional chiefs.

LOWY INTERPRETER

Australia's cash splash in Solomons will cost more than it delivers

The piece argues direct cash transfers to Solomon Islands parliamentarians, intended to build goodwill, may instead deepen the clientelist politics that undermines governance reform efforts Canberra has backed for years.

Argument: A plan to fund Solomon Islands MPs directly risks entrenching the patronage system Australia has long tried to reform.

BERNARD BROUGHTON · DEVPOLICY BLOG

The scandal that changed the sector: a whistleblower looks back

Written by a former CARE Australia director, the piece traces a chain of events, misconduct, a weak institutional response, a television exposé, and eventual reform, as a lesson for today's aid transparency debates.

Argument: A retrospective account of a 1990s financial misconduct scandal in the aid sector shows how weak initial responses, followed by exposure and audits, eventually produced a sector-wide code of conduct.

THE DIPLOMAT

Australia Launches Bid for a UN Security Council Seat

The Diplomat outlines Australia's campaign for a non-permanent Security Council seat, noting the shifted global and regional context compared with its previous tenure on the council.

Argument: Australia's bid to return to the UN Security Council in 2029 would unfold under markedly different circumstances than its last term.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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